to swear an oath of allegiance. A document pledging loyalty was hastily drawn up, to which they all attached their seals, and one by one confirmed this by placing their hands on a Quran: ‘At this happy moment when the sultan son of the sultan, Shahpur Shah, is our sovereign, we swear and certify by God and His Prophet and all the prophets . . . that we will not choose as Shah anyone but this illustrious ruler; with heart and soul we will not stint in our service to him; we consider obligatory that his orders be carried out by us, by the country, by the soldiery, and by the populace.’[101] Pollock refused however to supply the assembled nobility with any arms or ammunition, despite their pleas, so making their vows almost impossible to keep.[102] The speed of the army’s departure not only doomed the pro-British nobility; it also left many of the Company’s own sepoys in captivity. ‘We ought to have remained longer to have recovered more of our captive people,’ wrote a disgusted Colin Mackenzie. ‘Hundreds were left in slavery.’[103] Years later, he met an enslaved sepoy who had managed to escape from captivity and make his way back to India. From this man he learned, as he had suspected, that ‘the mountains were then full of our prisoners, many of whom were [later] sent off to Balkh as slaves. There were some English among them. Had our troops only been allowed to stay a few days longer they could all have been brought in.’[104]

At sunrise on 12 October 1842, the British lowered the Union Jack on the Bala Hisar, and, in the words of the Rev. I. N. Allen, ‘turned our backs on the scene of former disgrace and present outrage – a melancholy and disgraceful scene’.[105] Behind them, Neville Chamberlain could see ‘the whole face of the sky was red with flames’ and the last remaining quarters of Kabul still standing – all that was left of the city of gardens which Burnes had once thought the most beautiful in the region – well on their way to becoming a smouldering wreck. ‘Ruin and revenge had uprooted families and dwellings,’ wrote Munshi Abdul Karim. ‘Few distinguished citiziens were left; the bazaars had been pulled down; open spaces were heaped with corpses and filth and stench polluted the air. Once fine gardens were now the haunt of scavengers and owls: wretched beggars were left scrabbling in the dust.’[106]

If many of the troops were pleased to be heading back home to their Indian cantonments, the procession which left the city was nonetheless a sad spectacle, for along with the British trudged a whole variety of groups whose lives had been uprooted and ruined by Auckland’s failed adventure: